



What Is a Port in Networking?

So you've probably seen numbers like 80, 443, or 22 tossed around in networking guides. Ever wondered what those numbers really mean? Let's demystify it.

Prepared By: Hosni Zaaraoui

Think of Ports Like Doors Into Your Computer

Imagine your computer is a giant apartment building.

Each apartment has **its own door** with a number on it. When **a visitor** (like a web request) comes in, **the building** (your computer) needs to know **which door** (port) to knock on **to reach the right apartment** (service).

So in networking terms:

- Your computer/server = the building
- The port number = the door
- The service/application = the person/apartment inside

Why Ports Matter

When data arrives at your computer from the internet, the operating system needs to know which application to deliver it to.

Here's how it works:

- Every message comes with:
 - An IP address (**Where to send it**—like your building's address)
 - A Port number (**Who to give it to**—like the apartment number)

Types of Ports

There are **65,535 ports** in total for each IP address (numbered 0–65535), divided into 3 types:

- **Well-Known Ports (0–1023)**

Reserved for system-level services. Needs root privileges to use.

- **Registered Ports (1024–49151)**

Used by user-installed apps (e.g., PostgreSQL on port 5432).

- **Dynamic/Private Ports (49152–65535)**

Used temporarily for client-side connections (like when browsing).

So What Happens When You Visit a Website?

1

You type `https://example.com` into your browser.

2

Your browser connects to the IP address of the website.

3

It sends the request to port 443 (the HTTPS door).

4

The server's web app opens the door, processes the request, and sends the page back.

Why Knowing Ports Helps in Security

Firewalls, intrusion detection systems, and service configurations often **rely on ports to allow or block access**.

- If port 22 is open, someone might try to SSH in
- If port 80 is open, you're probably running a web server
- If random high ports are open, you might be vulnerable...

That's why knowing ports is networking 101 for sysadmins, DevOps engineers, and anyone serious about IT security



“Ports may just be numbers—but they play a huge role in communication.”